

Black Panther (2018)

AS Component 1: Investigating the Media A level Component 1: Media Products, Industries and Audiences

Focus areas: Media Industries Media Contexts

PRODUCT CONTEXT

- Black Panther is the 17th film in the 'Marvel Cinematic Universe', the highest-grossing film **franchise** in history. It was directed by Ryan Coogler (Creed) and released in February 2018.
- The film shows us the fictional African kingdom of **Wakanda**, which has avoided European colonisation and achieved a technological superiority through the use of a mineral called Vibranium. T'Challa (Chadwick Boseman) must fight a number of foes who oppose him becoming king after the death of his father.
- The film was produced by Marvel Studios, a famous comic book **brand** that is also a **subsidiary** of the Walt Disney Company.
- Black Panther was extremely successful, broke records for the highest opening weekend in the USA, and also performed well globally. The film has grossed well over \$1 billion worldwide, with 48% in non-US countries.
- It was also one of the only superhero films to be nominated for a 'Best Picture' **Academy Award**. It won three Oscars for Costume, Production Design, and Original Soundtrack.

PART 1: STARTING POINTS – Media Industries

Historical Context:

- From 15th-20th century, European powers **colonised** African countries and exploited the continent for both resources and slave labour. Africans were branded 'savages' by the European invaders, their cultures dismissed as 'primitive'.
- During the early 20th century, African-Americans attempted to establish a new black **cultural identity** with movements such as the Harlem Renaissance.
- The Black Panther Party (1966-82) was a **political activist** group established initially to

provide armed monitoring of police behaviour and prevent police brutality in the US. It was controversial, with many Panthers being arrested or killed in confrontations with police.

Cultural context:

- The science fiction blockbuster and superhero **genres** have traditionally been dominated by white, male characters. In the 1990s, actors like Will Smith and Wesley Snipes did break ground playing black characters, but recent action films and especially superhero films have rarely featured African-American actors in lead roles.
- For the last 15 years, Marvel films have topped the box office. Though these regularly featured non-white characters, they were often sidekicks (e.g. The Falcon in the Captain America films). There have also been very few superhero films with a female lead (Wonder Woman and Captain Marvel being exceptions).
- Black cinema has traditionally consisted of issues-based **social realism** (e.g. the films of Spike Lee) or have been '**arthouse**/'**prestige**' pictures (e.g. Moonlight, 2016). Blade (1998) is one of the few superhero films to have a black main character.
- In 2016, the #oscarssowhite meme drew attention to the **lack of diversity** in the films nominated.
- US/European news media tends to portray Africa as an under-privileged, developing country, focusing on civil wars, famine and terrorism. The Victorian branding of Africa as '**the Dark Continent**' has not evolved very far. Very few feature films from Africa reach the Western mainstream, and films like Blood Diamond (2006) and Captain Phillips (2013), though featuring sympathetic African characters, still portray Africa as a dangerous and barbaric place.
- Further study: research the cultural movement of '**Afrofuturism**'. What does this term mean? How have artists explored the idea in music, art, film and other media? To what extent is Black Panther an Afrofuturist film?

Economic and Political Contexts:

- Barack Obama (2009-2017), America's first African-American president, created many initiatives that aided minority and women's groups: from universal healthcare, to college and entrepreneurship